

Attempting to break my shaky streak, I then dated a woman in her 30s who was successful in her career. We were on a level playing field. She could pay for stuff as often as I could. She was also more masculine than me, and so in the beginning, she expected to pay for me by default. She was always shocked when I pulled out my wallet. I asked her why she thought she had to pay for me, and she said she hadn't ever thought about it too hard. Perhaps it was because I was presenting more femininely then. She just assumed she would pay even though we made a similar amount of money. She saw herself as "the dude." (That, again, is a shame because the best part of queer woman dating is there are no dudes. Write that down.)

After she and I split, I started noticing a pattern when I'd go on dates to restaurants with other women. When it came time to hand over the check, the server would give it to the more traditionally masculine of the two of us. Then, no matter who paid and who handed the check back to the server (regardless of gender), the server would hand the check back to the "masculine" person, assuming that's who was paying.

When I polled Twitter on the topic, 37 percent of the 2,300 people who responded to the poll said that in their experience, "the butch one" was always handed the check. User PossibilityLeft wrote, "Not only do they always hand it to me, I'm side-eyed if my femme gf pays instead." Many people who replied said the check was usually left in the middle, and former wait staff largely agreed that this was typical restaurant policy. But in my experience, the check is always handed to "the butch one." It's good to know stereotypical gender roles exist even in non-normative relationships. (JK, it sucks.)



I met my next serious boyfriend while working at BuzzFeed in 2015. My salary was higher than his, but as we got to know each other, I realized the more crucial difference was our completely opposite money scripts. I was a reckless spender, and he was a meticulous saver. He came from a wealthy family. My joke was that he looked like the type of guy who would tell a minimum-wage employee, "My